



Housing Recovery and
Reconstruction Platform



NRA, Building DLPIU Technical Staff Survey Report

August 2018



About HRRP

The Housing Recovery and Reconstruction Platform (HRRP) was established in December 2015 to take over supporting coordination of the post-earthquake housing reconstruction from the Nepal Shelter Cluster, as it returned to the pre-earthquake format as a standing cluster. The platform provides coordination support services for the National Reconstruction Authority (NRA), Building and Grant Management and Local Infrastructure (GMAIL) Central Level Programme Implementation Units (CLPIUs), other relevant government authorities, and Partner Organisations (POs). Phase 3 of the HRRP was approved by the Government of Nepal (GoN) at the beginning of March 2017 and will run until the end of February 2019. HRRP3 is primarily funded by DFID Nepal and CRS Nepal. Other financial contributors and implementing partners include Oxfam, Caritas Nepal, Plan International, National Society for Earthquake Technology-Nepal (NSET), and Habitat for Humanity.

The HRRP has 12 District Coordination Teams (DCTs) primarily focused on the 14 districts most affected by the 2015 Gorkha earthquake (1 team covers the three districts in the Kathmandu Valley) and providing support to the 18 moderately affected districts where feasible. The DCTs are made up of a Coordinator, a Technical Coordinator, and an Information Management Officer. The DCTs are supported by a District Management Team (DMT) made up of a Coordinator, Technical Coordinator, and Information Manager. The DMT provides day to day guidance and support to the DCTs as well as targeted capacity building and has a roving presence across all districts. The national team includes general coordination, technical coordination, and information management expertise and supports the link between national and district level.

Areas of Focus

The HRRP has four main areas of focus:

- Monitoring and documenting the housing reconstruction process
- Improving coverage and quality of socio-technical assistance
- Addressing gaps and duplications
- Advocacy and Communications

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I.0 Executive Summary

The technical staff from the Building District Level Programme Implementation Units (DLPIUs), under the National Reconstruction Authority (NRA), comprising engineers, sub-engineers, and assistant sub-engineers, are responsible for the inspection process associated with the disbursement of the Government of Nepal (GoN) housing reconstruction grant. The inspection process is defined in the GoN's 'Technical Inspection Guidelines for Housing Reconstruction, 2073'. The technical staff therefore play a hugely important role in the housing recovery and are often the GoN representatives on reconstruction who have most contact with households directly.

This survey was designed and launched with the following objectives:

- To understand how Building DLPIU technical staff access information and how they share it with households,
- To understand how to better support information sharing to technical staff and from technical staff to households,
- To gather more information on the experience of Building DLPIU technical staff and to increase focus on them and the important role they play in the reconstruction, and
- To provide space for Building DLPIU technical staff to share what support they feel they need.

The survey was initiated as part of a joint effort launched by the Housing Recovery and Reconstruction Platform (HRRP) and the UK's Department for International Development (DFID), with a wide range of reconstruction actors, in November 2017 to look at what factors are impacting households' reconstruction process in order to offer more effective, and targeted support. The survey was conducted using Google Forms and can be downloaded in English and Nepali from the HRRP Google Drive.

A total of 492 responses were received, with a minimum of 25 respondents from each of the 14 most affected districts as well as responses from Gulmi, Tanahun, Lamjung, Myagdi, Baglung, Bhojpur, Khotang, Arghakhanchi, and Nawalpur in the 18 moderately

affected districts. 63.6% of respondents were engineers (one respondent is an NRA District Support Engineer), 21.2% were sub-engineers, and 15.2% were assistant sub-engineers. The full dataset is available to download on the HRRP Google Drive.

Some of the major findings were:

- 51% of respondents did not receive training before deployment, 26% of respondents did not receive training after deployment, and just 35% of respondents had received training pre- and post deployment
- 85% of respondents reported that walking is their primary mode of transport for household visits
- 63% of respondents visit an average of 21-40 households each month
- 84% of respondents plan their inspection visits based on requests from households, and 62% plan their inspection visits in coordination with municipal / ward officials
- 45% of respondents reported facing pressure or threats from households to pass their house and 29% reported facing pressure or threats from ward / municipal officials to pass certain houses
- The most common source of information on reconstruction standards and policies, and any updates to these, was the NRA website with 80% of respondents reporting this as a source
- 73% of respondents reported receiving reconstruction updates from the DLPIU via phone calls and 35% of respondents reported receiving reconstruction updates from the DLPIU once a week
- 73% of respondents reported that their biggest challenge faced in sharing information with households is that it is difficult to convey complex concepts
- 87% of respondents reported that individual meetings with households are the best way to share information with households
- 49% of respondents reported that the most common question they are asked by households is 'when will we get our tranche?'. Other questions

that respondents reported being asked frequently included 'how can we address non-compliances?' and 'when are the GoN deadlines for disbursement of the tranches?'. Respondents also reported households frequently asking questions about technical options for house design and choice of construction materials. There were also several respondents who reported being asked by households about when they will receive the "4th tranche" of an additional 100,000 NPRs that was widely publicised in media earlier this year.

- In response to the question 'what support do you require to make it easier for you to do your job?' the most common requests were related to transport and training. Both were suggested by 25% or more of the respondents. Other areas where technical staff felt they needed support was on dealing with non-compliances, development of house designs which are appropriate for households, and accessing clear, correct, and timely information on reconstruction policies and technical guidelines, including regular updates from the DLPIUs and avoiding misinformation. Several respondents suggested that their attendance should not be approved by ward / municipal officials, but should be done by DLPIU representatives. Worryingly, this was suggested as the technical staff are facing threats from ward / municipal officials that their attendance sheets will not be approved if they do not approve certain houses for tranche disbursement.
- Respondents were asked to provide feedback on the coordination services provided by HRRP and to suggest changes / additions for HRRP extension beyond the current timeframe (end February 2019) that would make the platform more useful. Many respondents reported that HRRP has provided useful coordination services. They provided a lot of useful feedback on how to improve the services provided, including extending the reach at local level.

It was a major achievement and commitment by the government to hire such large numbers of technical staff and is a huge opportunity to build up technical capacity

in local authorities for the future. However, the results of the survey do seem to indicate that the impact of this initiative is not being fully realised and that without further investment from reconstruction actors (government and non-government) this will not be possible. The Building DLPIU technical staff are at the forefront of the reconstruction, working as the GoN's reconstruction representatives at household level. The importance of this role needs to be acknowledged in terms of the support that is provided to facilitate the staff to carry out their work.

Some immediate actions that are suggested considering the survey findings are as follows:

- Address transportation issues
- Add sections specifically for the Building DLPIU technical staff to the NRA (<http://nra.gov.np/np>) and MoUD CLPIU (<http://moudclpiu.gov.np/>) websites. The new municipal websites could also have sections dedicated to the technical staff.
- Development of the EHRP mobile application for all 32 earthquake affected districts as a tool to provide access to detailed updates on tranche disbursement based on each households PA number.
- Include social mobilisers as part of the Building DLPIU technical teams to support communication and engagement with households and communities
- Increase training and sharing opportunities for technical staff – both for reconstruction as well as looking to the long term
- Set up a backstopping system with senior engineers and social mobilisers available as roving support, focused on guidance and mentoring for Building DLPIU technical staff
- Facilitate regular coordination meetings between Building DLPIU, GMALI DLPIU, municipal officials, ward technicians, and Building DLPIU technical staff
- Conduct survey with Building DLPIU technical staff on a regular basis, e.g. every 3-4 months, to continue to track their experience

2.0 Background

The April 2015 Gorkha Earthquake caused loss of life and widespread damage to housing across almost 50% of the districts in Nepal. The Government of Nepal (GoN) launched an owner driven housing reconstruction programme which provides a financial grant of 300,000 NPRs for housing reconstruction or 100,000 NPRs for housing retrofit. The grants are provided in tranches which are only released if construction has met the required standards. The housing reconstruction grant is disbursed in three tranches; first tranche of 50,000 NPRs on signing the Partnership Agreement with the GoN, second tranche of 150,000 NPRs on completion of foundation, and 100,000 NPRs on completion of walls. A completion certificate is provided once the roof, and other finishing elements, are completed. The housing retrofit grant is disbursed in two tranches of 50,000 NPRs; the first on signing the Partnership Agreement with the GoN, and the second on completion of the retrofit.

As of August 2018, there are 807,486 households eligible for the housing reconstruction grant and a further 52,054 households are eligible for the housing retrofit grant – the scale of the housing recovery is enormous. As of 19 August 2018, 470,861 households have received the second tranche of the housing reconstruction grant and 231,670 households have received the third tranche. This leaves more than 575,000 households still to get through the grant process and to complete their housing reconstruction.

The Building District Level Programme Implementation Unit (DLPIU) technical staff – engineers, sub-engineers, and assistant sub-engineers – are responsible for the inspection process associated with the disbursement of the GoN housing reconstruction grant. The inspection process is defined in the GoN's 'Technical Inspection Guidelines for Housing Reconstruction, 2073'. The technical staff therefore play a hugely important role in the housing recovery and are often the GoN representatives on reconstruction who have most contact with households directly. The technical staff were deployed in the 14 most affected districts in June 2016 and in the 18 moderately affected districts in December 2017 with more than 3,000 technical staff spread across these districts.

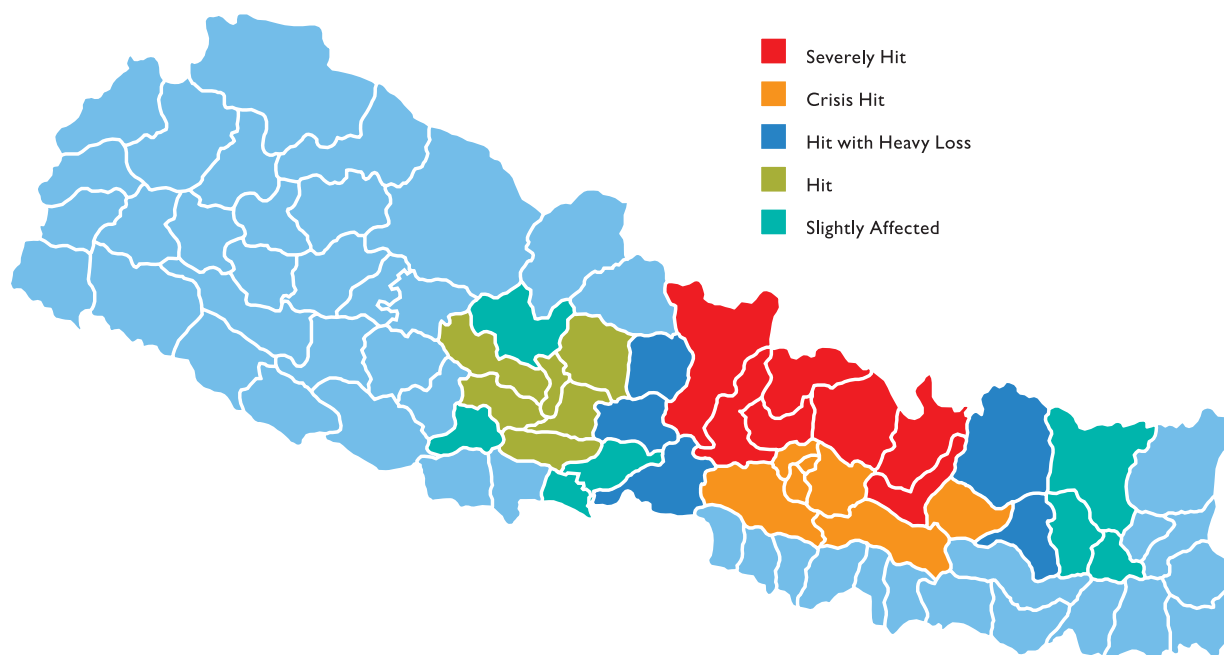
In November 2017, the Housing Recovery and

Reconstruction Platform (HRRP) and the UK's Department for International Development (DFID) launched an initiative with a wide range of reconstruction actors to look at what factors are impacting households' reconstruction process in order to offer more effective, and targeted support as more households start constructing. One of the action points decided by the 'Barriers and Drivers' working group was to conduct a survey with the Building DLPIU technical staff in order to better understand their experience of the reconstruction and how to support them.

The Building DLPIU technical staff have raised many issues about their working environment since deployment, including issues with contracts and allowances, lack of transport / challenges accessing working areas, lack of office space, internet, phone connection, etc. and need for more training and guidance.

There have also been complaints about technical staff from households and reconstruction actors. For example, many households report that they cannot get the technical staff to visit them, they are being told over the phone to proceed with their construction only to find it is non-compliant when an inspection visit happens, and that they are receiving contradictory information from different technical staff. Both government and non-government reconstruction actors at national, district, and municipal level have reported frustration with the technical staff as they are only recommending the house designs from the DUDBC design catalogues, many of which are not appropriate for earthquake affected areas. They have also reported that some of the technical staff did not receive even basic training prior to their deployment, lack communication skills, and are not polite and professional with the households they are interacting with.

Since the technical staff were deployed there have been many changes in the GoN's structure, both directly related to the technical staff, and more generally for the whole country. On the 12 April 2018, the Ministry of Urban Development (MoUD) Central and District Level Programme Implementation Units (CLPIU and DLPIUs) become the Building CLPIU and DLPIUs and moved under the NRA¹. The country's first local elections in over 20 years took place in May, June, and September 2017 and provincial and federal elections were held in



Earthquake affected districts as per Post-Disaster Needs Assessment (PDNA) classifications.

November 2017. The technical staff are now part of the new Rural and Urban Municipalities of which there are 282 across the 32 earthquake affected districts.

Looking to the future, the technical capacity that the Building DLPIU technical staff add at municipal level, along with the experience they are gaining during the reconstruction, has the potential be an important starting point for developing municipal capacity to implement the building code beyond the housing reconstruction. There are already examples of Building DLPIU technical staff having a positive influence on building code implementation at municipal level, including:

- In Pokhara Lekhnath Metropolitan City, Kaski, some of the house designs and houses were approved by the Metropolitan Building Design Department even though they did not fulfill the minimum requirements as set out in the inspection process. NRA, Building DLPIU technical staff influenced the Metropolitan engineers to endorse the minimum requirements and building code fully. This means that the previous practice of approving RCC houses with no banding has now stopped.
- In Byas Municipality, Tanahun, the Building Code Implementation Project Nepal (BCIPN) led by NSET was building up capacity by conducting trainings to engineers and municipality staff before the 2015 Gorkha earthquake. Following the earthquake an

exchange visit was conducted with engineers and local authority representatives from Gorkha. The exchange visit provided an opportunity for Gorkha Municipality to discuss building code implementation and to learn from RCC demonstration model that was constructed in municipality boundary. Byas Municipality has a good design registration process followed by government inspection to ensure application of building codes since before the earthquake. Byas municipality is also a good example of a well-planned urban settlement with regulations setup and monitored by the municipality.

However, there are also examples of municipal engineers not having a positive engagement with the reconstruction process. This includes in Dakshinkali, Kathmandu where the Common Feedback Project's community perception survey conducted in August 2018, collected some concerning reports that municipal engineers there are charging as much as 36,000 NPRs to develop house designs and are charging households up to 2,000 NPRs per building inspection visit.

It was a major achievement and commitment by the government to hire such large numbers of technical staff. It represents an important moment for the country, retaining so many technical people who might otherwise have migrated for work, and is a huge opportunity to build up technical capacity in local authorities for the future.

¹ Organisational Restructure in National Reconstruction Authority, NRA Website, Published 6 April 2018

3.0 Objectives and Methodology

The objectives of the survey were as follows:

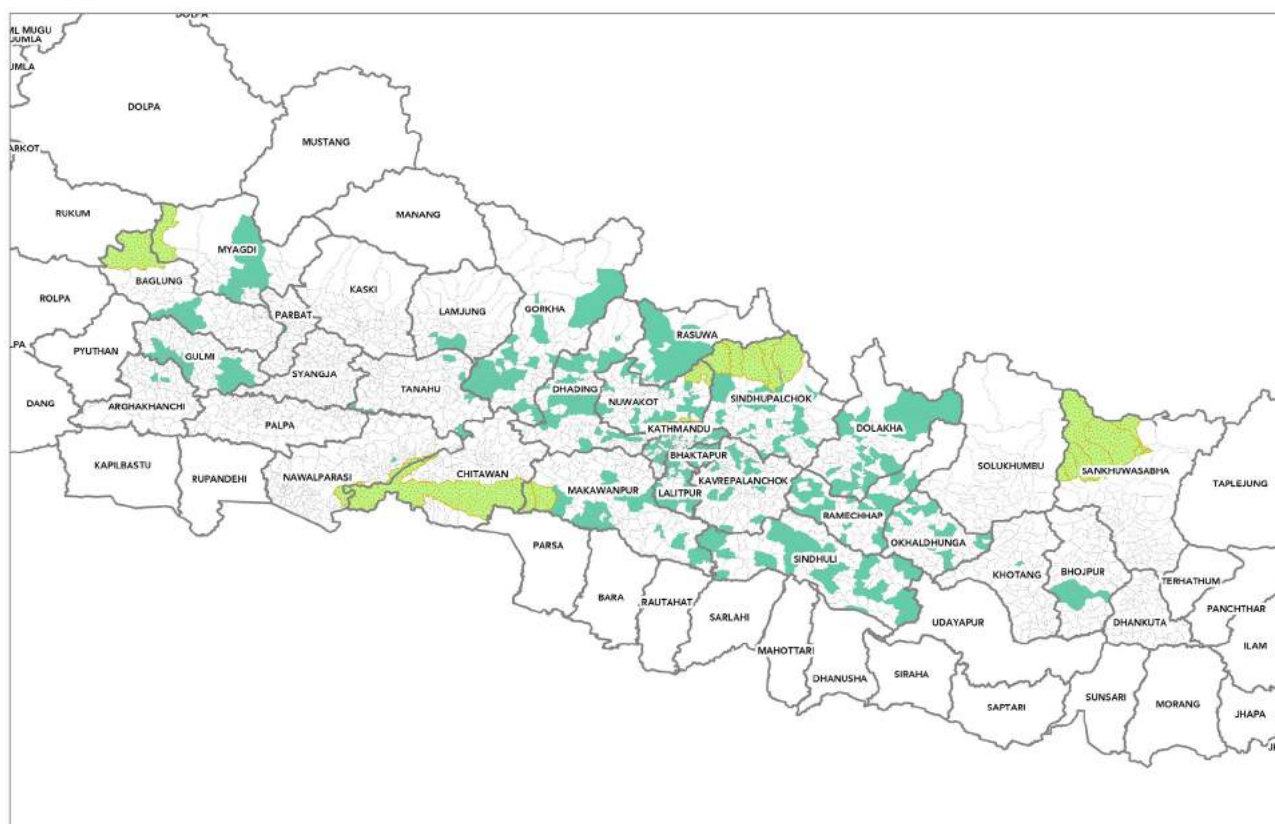
- To understand how Building DLPIU technical staff access information and how they share it with households,
- To understand how to better support information sharing to technical staff and from technical staff to households,
- To gather more information on the experience of Building DLPIU technical staff and to increase focus on them and the important role they play in the reconstruction, and

- To provide space for Building DLPIU technical staff to share what support they feel they need.

The survey was conducted using Google Forms. The form was circulated to Building DLPIU technical staff in the 14 most affected districts through the HRRP District Coordination Teams (DCTs) and through DLPIU contacts in the 18 moderately affected districts. The survey form can be downloaded in English and Nepali at: https://drive.google.com/drive/folders/1UoyZWNBu94V3fwYNxIB_6SN3jRZtAVZj

A total of 492 responses were received, with a minimum of 25 respondents from each of the 14 most

affected districts.



4.1 Recruitment and Training

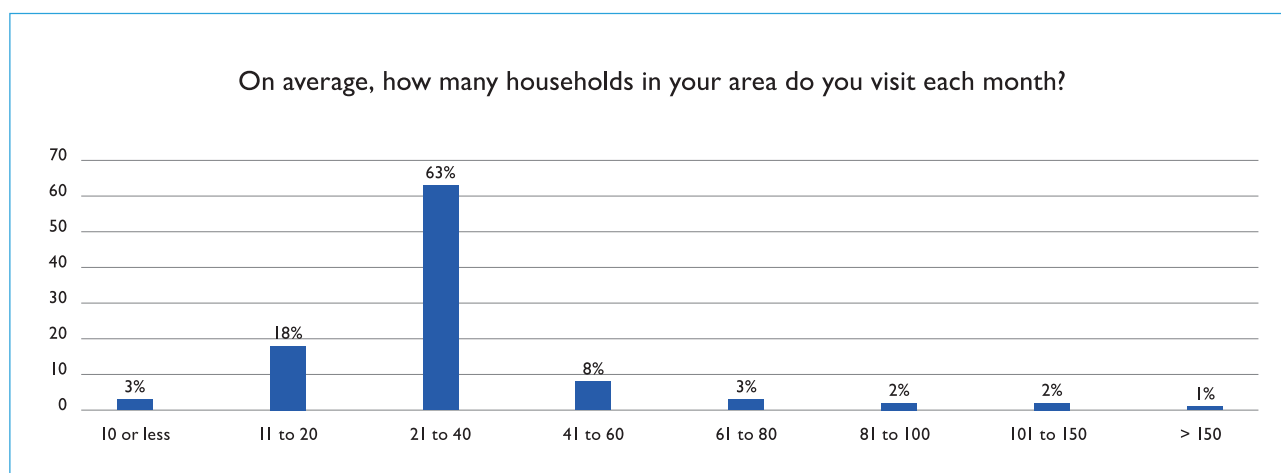
26% of respondents did not receive training after deployment. Of those that had received training after deployment, 48% had completed Training of Trainers (ToT) for the 7-day masons training, 31% completed basic retrofitting training, 31% took part in an orientation on the Corrections and Exceptions Manual, 16% took part in an orientation on the Repair and Retrofit Manual, and 14% completed training on technical inspection for housing reconstruction.

35% of respondents received training pre- and post deployment.

4.2 Inspection Visits

85% of respondents reported that walking is their primary mode of transport for household visits. Other modes of transport used for household visits included personal motorbike (28%), local bus (24%), and motorbike provided by work (12%). The total is greater than 100% as respondents could select multiple responses for this question.

Most respondents (63%) visit an average of 21-40 households each month.

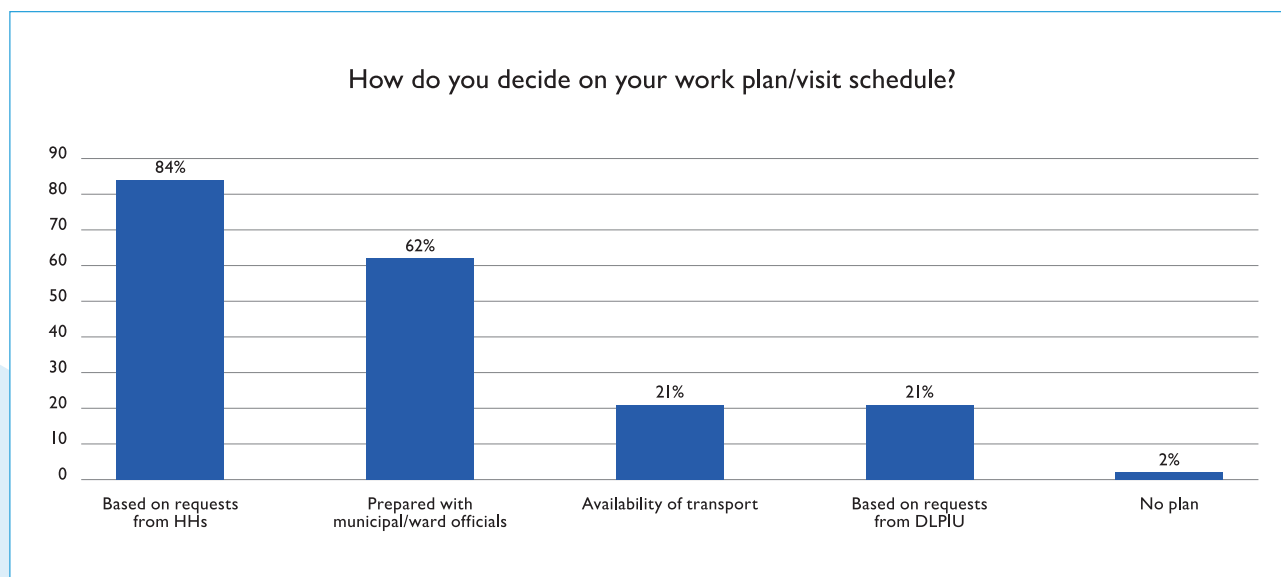


The majority of respondents (34%) reported each inspection visit taking them an average of 30 mins to 1 hour. 30% reported visits taking an average of 15 to 30 minutes, 16% reported an average of 3 or more hours, 13% reported an average of 1 to 2 hours, and 7% reported visits taking less than 15 minutes.

On average, respondents spent 23% of time during each household visit offering technical advice on building,

19% carrying out inspections for compliance, 18% on data management / paperwork, 17% on explaining the reconstruction and inspection process to households, 15% taking photos of the house, and 9% on other work.

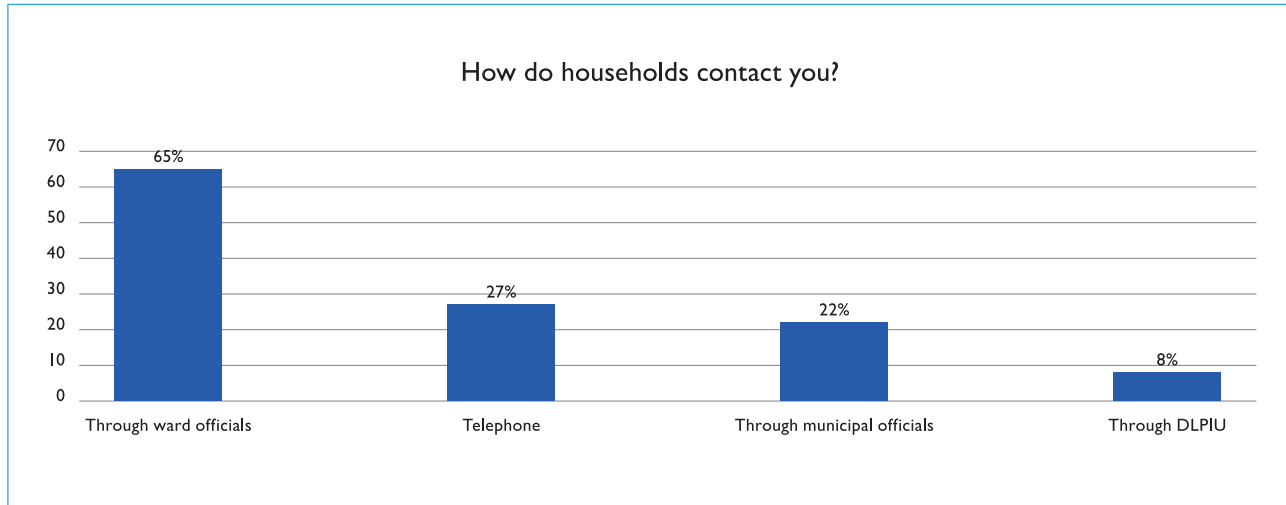
Most respondents plan their inspection visits based on requests from households (84%) and in coordination with municipal / ward officials (62%). 2% of respondents reported that they don't have a plan for inspection visits.



45% of respondents reported facing pressure or threats from households to pass their house and 29% reported facing pressure or threats from ward / municipal officials to pass certain houses.

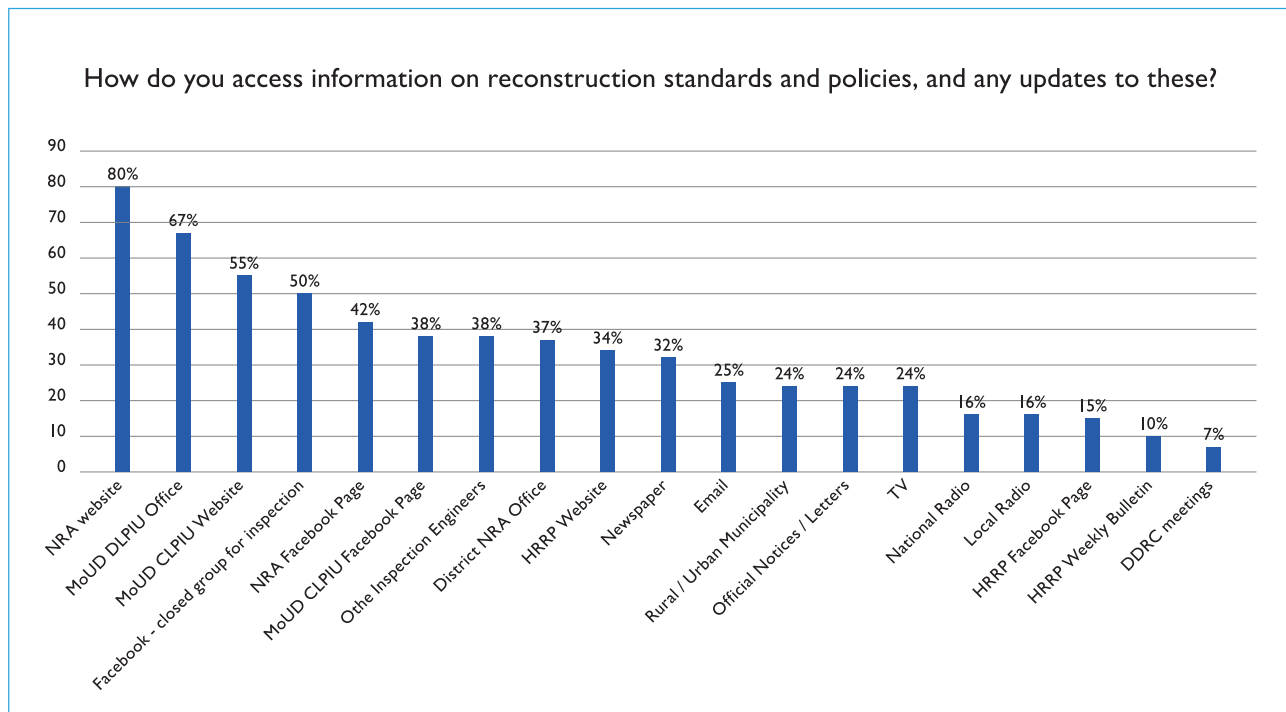
4.3 Access to and Dissemination of Information

The main way that respondents reported being contacted by households was through ward officials.



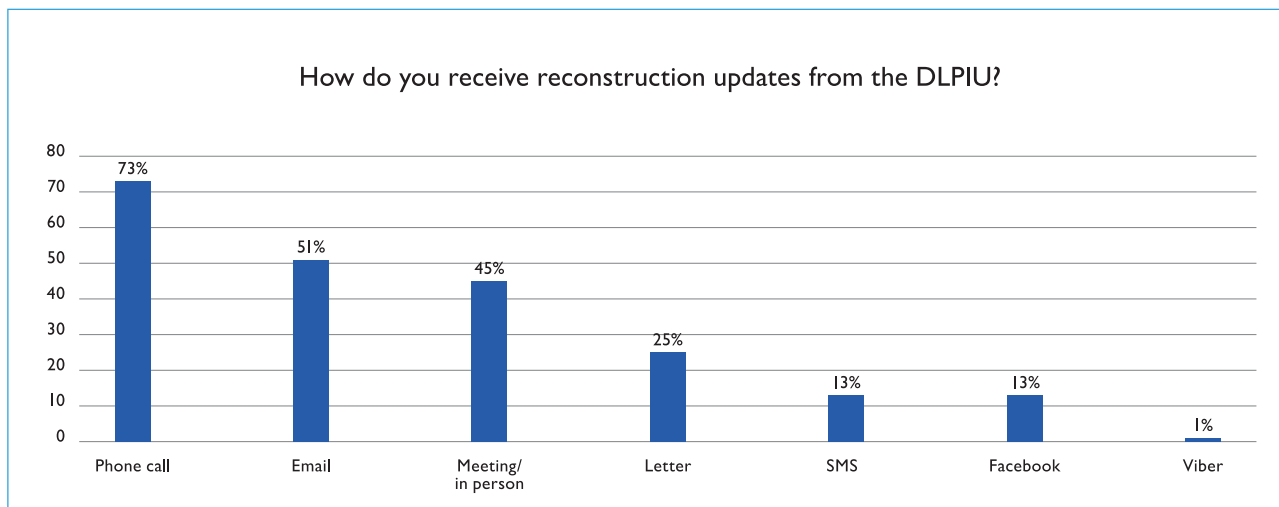
Somewhat surprisingly, given technical staff often work in areas with limited internet connectivity, the most common source of information on reconstruction

standards and policies, and any updates to these, was the NRA website with 80% of respondents reporting this as a source.

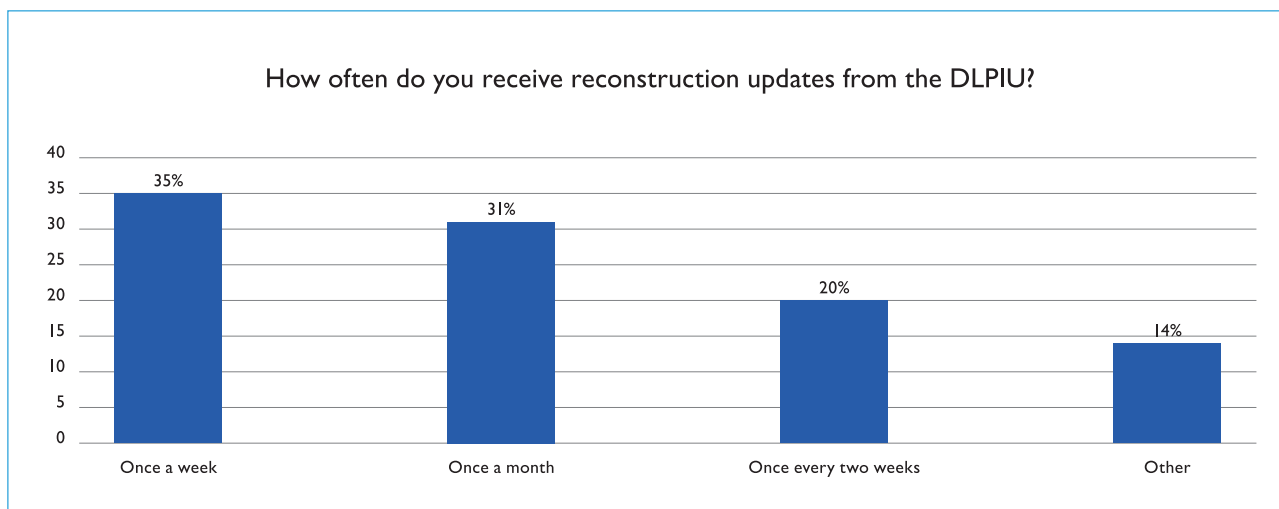


Phone calls are the most common way respondents reported receiving reconstruction updates from the DLPIU with email (51%) and meetings / in person (45%)

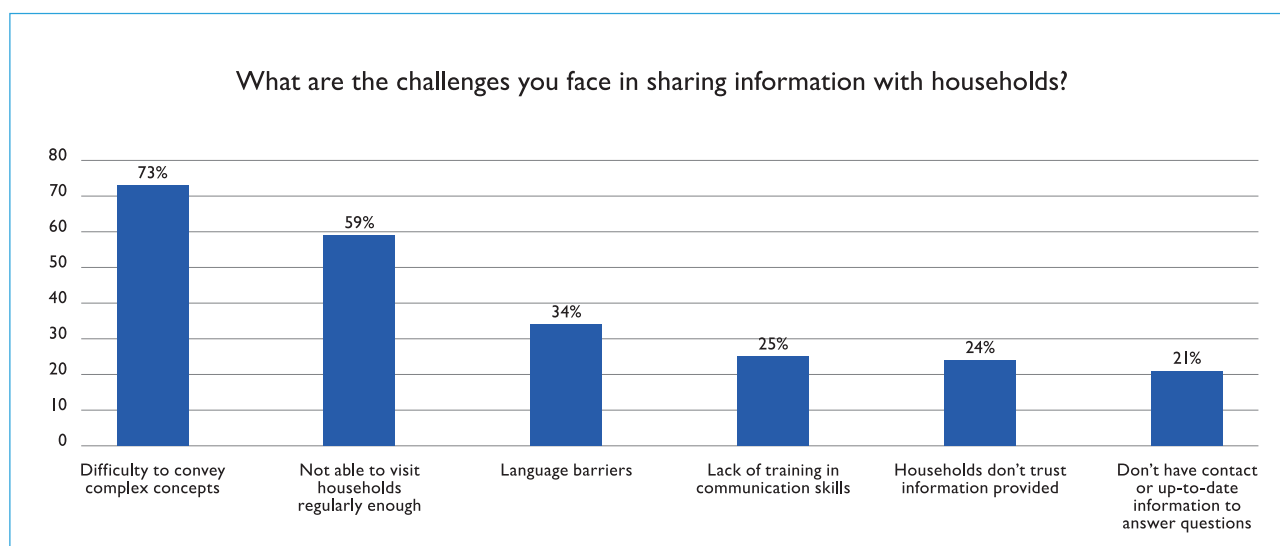
the next most common ways updates are received. One respondent reported that they have never received any updates from DLPIU.



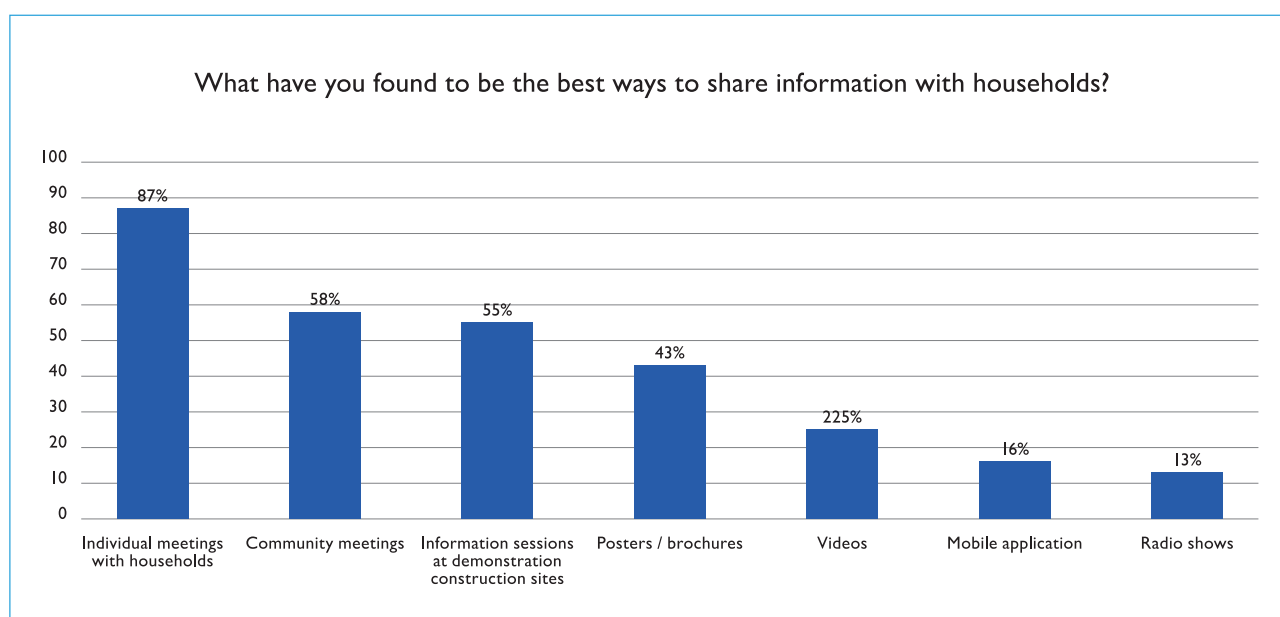
Most respondents (35%) reported receiving reconstruction updates from the DLPIU once a week.



The majority of respondents (73%) reported that their biggest challenge faced in sharing information with households is that it is difficult to convey complex concepts.



87% of respondents reported that individual meetings with households are the best way to share information with households.



49% of respondents reported that the most common question they are asked by households is 'when will we get our tranche?'. Other questions that respondents reported being asked frequently included:

- How can we address non-compliances? Will the NRA provide any additional funds for carrying out corrections? One respondent reported that households regularly suggest that houses constructed before arrival of technical staff should be approved for all tranches without having to make corrections as the households had no support and needed to progress with rebuilding their house.
- When are the GoN deadlines for tranche disbursement? What happens if we haven't built before the deadlines pass?
- How can I register a grievance? When will my grievance be addressed?
- What are the earthquake resistant elements that I need to include in my house for it to be safe?
- How can we build a house for 300,000 NPRs?
- How can we get the 2% loan that the government announced (up to 15 lakhs outside the Kathmandu Valley and up to 25 lakhs in the Kathmandu Valley)?

Valley)? How can we get the interest free loan the government announced (up to 300,000 NPRs based on community collateral)?

Respondents also reported households frequently asking questions about technical options for house design and choice of construction materials, e.g. how can we build with hollow concrete blocks, why are we not allowed to build timber houses, why can't we build two storey stone and mud mortar masonry houses, where are vertical and horizontal bands required, etc. There were also several respondents who reported being asked by households about when they will receive the "4th tranche" of an additional 100,000 NPRs that was widely publicised in media earlier this year.

4.4 Support Required

The most common requests for support were, unsurprisingly, transport and training. Both of these were suggested by 25% or more of the respondents – "it has become a challenge for me to visit houses frequently since I am just one engineer appointed to cover the whole Rural Municipality (8 wards) with one assistant sub-engineer. We are not provided with any transportation facilities so it has become difficult to monitor the houses under construction. I think at least one engineer should be placed in every ward to properly monitor and support the construction". One respondent suggested that "if the ward members could facilitate households to form groups that we could visit at the same time it would be more effective than how we are called directly by individual households to make visits".

Other areas where respondents felt they require support are:

- Dealing with non-compliances – "About 135 houses of different typologies have been constructed before we were deployed and they are non-compliant. We need technical support to carry out proper analysis and to provide guidance on what corrections are required".
- Additional staff – many respondents felt that their working area was too large, and that they would benefit from having additional social mobilisers or local representatives / local volunteers / focal points at community level working with them to support with community engagement and interactions with households. Some respondents also suggested that it would be useful to have an administrative person to support the technical staff.
- Accessing clear, correct, and timely information on reconstruction policies and technical guidelines, including regular updates from the DLPIUs and avoiding misinformation – "don't publish unauthorised news in the media, e.g. 2 lakh no interest loan,

providing second and third tranches in one go, every house will be approved to receive the tranches even if the structure does not meet the guidelines, 2% subsidy loans from banks of up to 25 or 15 lakhs, etc."

- Development of house designs which are appropriate for households – several respondents highlighted that the catalogue designs are not appropriate for households and that this is a challenge they face regularly in their work.
- Tranche disbursement process – many respondents suggested that the process should be faster, and that issues with data management need to be addressed. "DCC makes huge mistakes when checking files after they are forwarded by DLPIU so I suggest the employees to check the files properly". They also suggested that they need more information on the process; "there should be regular information on how many households have received the 2nd and 3rd tranche of the GoN housing reconstruction grant sent to email address"
- Improved working environment – many respondents highlighted that they need office space, access to a printer and internet, a tablet for inspection data collection, a laptop, electricity, and camera.
- Several respondents suggested that their attendance should not be approved by ward / municipal officials, but should be done by DLPIU representatives. Worryingly, this was suggested as the technical staff are facing threats from ward / municipal officials that their attendance sheets will not be approved if they do not approve certain houses for tranche disbursement – "if we are working directly under the DLPIU then nobody can pressure us to pass particular houses. At the moment we have to pass houses that the ward officials tell us to, otherwise they will not approve our attendance and we will not receive our salary". In addition to this, some respondents reported that the monthly salary and allowances are not sufficient and are not paid in a timely manner.
- Security – many respondents suggested that they need local people to work with them as security and protection! Respondents also suggested that they need support on developing better understanding and trust with households.
- Support from local authorities – some respondents reported that the working relationship with local officials is difficult; "we should have full support from local bodies. They think that it is not their duty to be involved in the reconstruction programme. Although we are the technical staff designated to support the reconstruction they treat us like refugees. They provide no help and no coordination".
- Support from senior engineers – respondents suggested that regular visits from, and interaction

with, senior engineers would benefit their work and build their capacity to deal with the technical issues they are facing in the field.

- Coordination – between all groups working on the reconstruction – “there should be joint coordination between Building DLPIU, GMALI DLPIU, ward technicians, and municipal officials. If this happens most problems faced in the reconstruction can be solved”. One respondent also suggested that the Building DLPIU technical staff should receive training on coordination. Another respondent suggested that it would be better if municipal officials were part of the visits to households conducted by the technical staff.

4.5 Feedback on HRRP

Respondents were asked to provide feedback on the coordination services provided by HRRP and to suggest changes / additions for HRRP extension beyond the current timeframe (end February 2019) that would make the platform more useful. When providing feedback on coordination services provided by HRRP, 29% of respondents reported that HRRP is ‘doing a good job’ and providing useful support, 5% reported that HRRP is doing ‘an average or satisfactory job’, and 7% of respondents recommended that HRRP should continue, with many of these recommending that continuation should also include further reach to local level.

Other respondents provided a wide range of recommendations and requests for support, including:

- Many respondents recommended having more focus on urban reconstruction highlighting the slower pace of reconstruction in these areas and the complexity urban reconstruction – “HRRP should come forward in urban reconstruction work by uniting all concerned ward members, ward officials and elected municipal bodies. There has lots to be done in urban reconstruction.”
- There were some recommendations to include support for building code implementation under HRRP
- “HRRP should encourage provision of training for technical people working for reconstruction”. Many respondents recommended that these events should be held regularly with most suggesting monthly, and one suggesting every three months. Suggestions included:
 - o “organise meetings amongst Engineers, officials, MOUD DLPIU, MOFALD DLPIU, District Treasury Office and NRA officials once in a month”
 - o “should conduct a meeting and discussion programme at least once a month to know about the complexity of work in the field and plan a way forward”
- o “should conduct training and motivational programs regularly. Should speak about the problems faced by DLPIU engineers”
- o “coordination related training should be provided”
- o “In depth training should be provided, not only introductory sessions, on topics such as retrofitting, structural analysis, and other topics related to civil engineering”
- “HRRP is playing vital role in reconstruction by coordinating local people and technical people and elected body at local level.”
- Several respondents recommended HRRP having a strengthened information sharing system to get information to the Building DLPIU technical staff with most recommending use of telephone and email for this. Suggestions included:
 - o “it would be better if you can make an app that can provide all updates and information related to reconstruction”
 - o “I think HRRP should hold an exhibition programme in every VDC”
 - o “HRRP coordination office should support for information and updates”

There was one respondent who shared that “HRRP is good in providing information about reconstruction. They should continue it.”

- Many respondents suggested that more support is required for the tranche disbursement process, highlighting that there is a time lag between approval to receive the second or third tranche and the household actually receiving the tranche. Suggestions included:
 - o “the name list for all households that have received the 2nd and 3rd tranches HHs should be published on HRRP website”
 - o “HRRP should provide information on how many beneficiaries’ tranche has been deposited to bank”
 - o “if you can, please provide required support on pending files of the beneficiaries to bring them in process again”
 - o “If they could send mail or SMS to us about the information about tranche deposited in bank”
 - o “HRRP should put pressure on the banks as they give a lot of struggle to households and even don’t give money on time”.
- “HRRP should try reconstruction of few thousands houses by itself, as a role model.”

There was also some negative feedback, including:

- “No any help. Useless organisation”
 - “HRRP is not is not up to the mark.”
 - “Focal person who spread over district or particular Rural Municipality are rarely help in tranche distribution.”
 - “I don't really see the coordination of HRRP. I, personally haven't heard anyone mention about HRRP support.”
 - “HRRP support for technicians is very less - it should be increased.”
 - “I have not yet received any technical advice or any kind of support from HRRP.”
 - “HRRP lacks the coordination with the field technicians of GoN. I think they should start to coordinate fully with GoN staffs also rather than only focusing on NGO and INGOs.”
- “Housing recovery and reconstruction platform, the term sounds so promising but I regret to say that it hasn't been in the picture of the reconstruction process. Having worked in the field of reconstruction from the very beginning of its commencement I got to know about HRRP's existence only recently. It might have been successful in its job in other districts but talking about where I work, I do not see any active participation from HRRP in the ongoing reconstruction process.”
 - “I feel there are some coordination issues between local bodies and HRRP so we need to sort that for better performance”

There were also some respondents that reported that they were very glad to have the opportunity to share their responses through the survey; “we are really glad that HRRP gave us this opportunity to share our experience and obstacles. Hope it will give us positive results or it will help to make our job a little bit easier, thank you”, “this work is fantastic to give our opinion”.

5.0 Conclusions and Next Steps

The survey responses have provided interesting insight into the Building DLPIU technical staffs' experience of reconstruction.

There are some worrying aspects of this experience including that nearly half of respondents reported facing pressure or threats from households to pass their house and almost a third have faced pressure or threats from ward / municipal officials to pass certain houses. Respondents also reported that the ward / municipal officials that are responsible for approving their attendance withhold approval if the technical staff will not approve certain houses based on their requests. In response to the question 'what support do you require to make it easier for you to do your job?' many respondents suggested that they need support to address security issues they face in the communities where they work.

Training and continuous backup and support are clearly major issues for the Building DLPIU technical staff. Just 49% of respondents reported receiving training before deployment and 74% of respondents had received training after deployment with just 35% of respondents receiving training pre- and post deployment. In response to the question 'what support do you require to make it easier for you to do your job?' and in the feedback provided for HRRP, many respondents recommended that they be provided with more training opportunities as well as motivational and discussion programmes to work through issues they are facing.

With almost 75% of respondents reporting that the biggest challenge they face in sharing information with households being that it is difficult to convey complex concepts, it is clear that the technical staff need additional support to ensure that they can work effectively with households and provide the support and guidance households require.

It was a major achievement and commitment by the government to hire such large numbers of technical staff. It represents an important moment for the country, retaining so many technical people who might otherwise have migrated for work, and is a huge opportunity to build up technical capacity in local authorities for the future. However, the results

of the survey do seem to indicate that the impact of this initiative is not being fully realised and that without further investment from reconstruction actors (government and non-government) this will not be possible. The Building DLPIU technical staff are at the cold face of the reconstruction, working as the GoN's reconstruction representatives at household level. The importance of this role needs to be acknowledged in terms of the support that is provided to facilitate the staff to carry out their work.

The Building DLPIU technical staff have themselves provided an outline of the next steps required based on the responses to the question 'what support do you require to make it easier for you to do your job?' and in the feedback provided for HRRP. The following are suggested next steps that could be considered as immediate actions to be taken in light of the responses to this survey:

- Address transportation issues: if the impact of the Building DLPIU technical staff is to be maximised they need to be able to move around and visit households as needed. Improving their transport facilities will require additional investment from reconstruction actors and needs urgent attention from government, donors, and partner organisations
- As the NRA (<http://nra.gov.np/np>) and MoUD CLPIU (<http://moudclpiu.gov.np/>) websites are such important sources of information for the technical staff it would be useful to set up sections on both websites specifically for them. These sections could be designed to be more interactive, provide links to relevant documents, have a questions and answers section, etc. This initiative could also be linked with the new municipal websites.
- Development of the EHRP mobile application for all 32 earthquake affected districts. This app, which is currently only available for Rasuwa, provides detailed updates on tranche disbursement based on each households PA number. This tool could address many of the issues raised by the technical staff in relation to having access to information on the tranche disbursement status.
- Include social mobilisers as part of the Building

DLPIU technical teams to support communication and engagement with households and communities. Technical staff alone are not the answer, and the results of the survey clearly show that there are issues with their capacity to communicate with households and to address challenges in community engagement. Scaling up the presence of social mobilisers working in a team with the Building DLPIU technical staff may have a very positive effect on this.

- Increase training and sharing opportunities for technical staff – both for reconstruction as well as looking to the long term. Many of the technical staff have not received any training or guidance on application of the building code which would greatly support set up of building code implementation at municipal level. Training to address reconstruction issues or processes, can also be expanded to include this.
- Set up a backstopping system with senior engineers and social mobilisers available as roving support, focused on guidance and mentoring for Building DLPIU technical staff. There are currently District Support Engineers (DSEs) covering the 32 most affected districts but the DSEs are primarily focused on addressing challenging technical issues that

arise at district level, particularly non-compliances. It is suggested that having roving teams of senior engineers and social mobilisers who could focus on supporting the Building DLPIU technical staff, including conducting monitoring visits, could be very useful.

- Facilitate regular coordination meetings between Building DLPIU, GMALI DLPIU, municipal officials, ward technicians, and Building DLPIU technical staff (HRRP, NRA, Building CLPIU and DLPIUs, GMALI CLPIU and DLPIUs, MoFAGA, Partner Organisations, donors). Some Partner Organisations have already applied similar approach with great success. For example, JICA have been holding community meetings on specific issues with the households affected by these issues, the technical staff, and ward / municipal officials. This provides a forum for collective problem solving, with coordination and collaboration amongst all actors involved.
- Conduct survey with Building DLPIU technical staff on a regular basis, e.g. every 3-4 months, to continue to track their experience (HRRP, NRA, Building CLPIU and DLPIUs)



Jwagal, Kupondole, Lalitpur, Nepal

+977-1-5544149

info@hrrpnepal.org

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